

Chapter 4 — Jñāna-Karma-Sannyāsa Yoga

ज्ञानकर्मसंन्यासयोगः : జ్ఞానకర్మసన్యాసయోగము

"The Yoga of Knowledge & Renunciation of Action" · 42 verses · Action illumined by wisdom

Chapter 4 introduces the **third pillar** — **jñāna (knowledge)** — and shows how it weaves together with karma. Kṛṣṇa reveals that this same teaching is **eternal**, transmitted from sage to sage in an unbroken lineage. He declares the principle of **avatāra** — the Divine's repeated descent into the world to restore *dharma* — and teaches the great paradox: "He who sees inaction in action, and action in inaction — he is the wise one among men."

Companion sheets for this chapter:

• [yada yada.html](#) — full word-by-word for BG 4.7 & 4.8 (*yadā yadā hi dharmasya + paritrāṇāya sādḥūnām*) — the principle of *avatāra*.

• [ch04_ga/ga_jnana_yoga.html](#) — a running Q&A on Jñāna Yoga: 4.7–4.10 · Advaita reading · 4.16–4.18 · fighting injustice as a jñānī · 4.19–4.23 · the great *brahmārpaṇam* mantra (4.24) · householder's charter (4.20) with Janaka & Gandhi · five factors of action (18.13–17) · three karmas & *jñānāgni* · karaṇas & instrument-anatomy · twelve yajñas (4.25–4.33) · raft & fire (4.36–4.37) · guru-śiṣya method (4.34) · closing charge (4.42) · mechanics of rebirth.

Other essential verses of Chapter 4

BG 4.18 The wise see inaction in action and action in inaction

कर्मण्यकर्म यः पश्येदकर्मणि च कर्म यः ।

स बुद्धिमान्मनुष्येषु स युक्तः कृत्स्नकर्मकृत् ॥ ४.१८ ॥

కర్మణ్యకర్మ యః పశ్యేదకర్మణి చ కర్మ యః ।

స బుద్ధిమాన్మనుష్యేషు స యుక్తః కృత్స్నకర్మకృత్ ॥ ౪.౧౮ ॥

karmaṇy akarma yaḥ paśyed akarmaṇi ca karma yaḥ |

sa buddhimān manuṣyeṣu sa yuktaḥ kṛtsna-karma-kṛt ||

"One who sees inaction in action, and action in inaction — that one is wise among men, established in yoga, doing all action."

The paradox: external work done with inner stillness is *true* action; external stillness with inner agitation is *not*.

BG 4.34 The method of learning — approach a teacher with humility and questioning

तद्विद्धि प्रणिपातेन परिप्रश्नेन सेवया ।

उपदेक्ष्यन्ति ते ज्ञानं ज्ञानिनस्तत्त्वदर्शिनः ॥ ४.३४ ॥

తద్విద్ధి ప్రణిపాతేన పరిప్రశ్నేన సేవయా ।

ఉపదేక్ష్యంతి తే జ్ఞానం జ్ఞానినస్తత్త్వదర్శినః ॥ ౪.౩౪ ॥

tad viddhi praṇipātena paripraśnena sevayā |

upadeksyanti te jñānaṁ jñāninas tattva-darśinaḥ ||

"Know this by approaching the wise with prostration, with sincere inquiry, and with service.

Those who have seen the truth will instruct you in knowledge."

The classic verse on *guru-paramparā* — the spiritual relationship.

Word-by-Word — 4.34 (how to learn)

IAST	तद्विद्धि	तद् विद्धि	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>tat viddhi</i>	तद् विद्धि	तद् विद्धि	tad VID-dhi	know that
<i>praṇipātena</i>	प्रणिपातेन	ప్రణిపాతేన	pra-ni-PAA-te-na	by prostration, humble approach
<i>paripraśnena</i>	परिप्रश्नेन	పరిప్రశ్నేన	pa-ri-PRASH-ne-na	by thorough questioning, sincere inquiry
<i>sevayā</i>	सेवया	సేవయా	SE-va-yaa	by service

IAST	उपदेक्ष्यन्ति	ఉపదేక్ష్యంతి	PRONUNCIATION	MEANING
<i>upadekṣyanti</i>	उपदेक्ष्यन्ति	ఉపదేక్ష్యంతి	u-pa-DEK-shyan-ti	they will instruct, teach
<i>te</i>	ते	తే	te	to you
<i>jñānam</i>	ज्ञानम्	జ్ఞానమ్	GYAA-nam	knowledge
<i>jñāninaḥ</i>	ज्ञानिनः	జ్ఞానినః	GYAA-ni-nah	the wise ones
<i>tattva-darśinaḥ</i>	तत्त्वदर्शिनः	తత్త్వదర్శినః	TAT-tva-DAR-shi-nah	the seers of truth

BG 4.38 *Nothing in this world purifies like knowledge*

न हि ज्ञानेन सदृशं पवित्रमिह विद्यते ।

तत्त्वयं योगसंसिद्धः कालेनात्मनि विन्दति ॥ ४.३८ ॥

న హి జ్ఞానేన సదృశం పవిత్రమిహ విద్యతే ।

తత్త్వయం యోగసంసిద్ధః కాలేనాత్మని విందతి ॥ ౪.౩౮ ॥

na hi jñānena sadṛśaṁ pavitram iha vidyate |

tat svayam yoga-saṁsiddhaḥ kālenātmāni vindati ||

"In this world, there is nothing as purifying as knowledge.
The one perfected in yoga, in time, finds it of himself, in himself."

□ Essential take-away of Chapter 4

Action illumined by knowledge does not bind.

Karma-Yoga + Jñāna together: **do your work, but with the understanding of who you really are.** This is "action in inaction" — outwardly engaged, inwardly free.

The Lord descends (*avatāra*) again and again to teach this; you can receive it the same way the sages always have: with **humility, inquiry, and service** (4.34).